

on it more than you would on the spell-checkers and other grammar-checking tools in your word processor!

OpenOffice.org 2.1

<http://openoffice.org>

In full-featured, free office suites, OpenOffice.org (Ooo) is one of our perennial favourites and needs no fresh introduction. The latest version is a maintenance release with some minor improvements. For newbies to the Ooo culture here's a quick recap.

This office suite consists of Writer for word processing, Calc for spreadsheeting functions, Impress to create presentations, Math for writing mathematical formulas, Draw for basic drawing, and Base to create ad hoc database applications.

The biggest attraction is that you get all these capabilities at the unbelievable price: Free. Comparing with the more heavyweight and popular rival Microsoft Office, there are some pluses and minuses. If you are looking at the Rs 15,000 plus price tag, then, of course, Ooo wins hands down. In terms of functionality, admittedly, there are differences in working. Things taken for granted in MS Office will need to be relearned. While many keyboard shortcuts are the same, as in [Ctrl] + [S] = Save, [Ctrl] + [V] = Paste, and so on, some shortcuts won't work—for example, [Ctrl] + [D] in Excel will fill down the contents of a cell; in Ooo this is a bit more cumbersome.

These minor inconveniences aside, you might find some of the features in Ooo more gratifying—like the inbuilt one-click PDF converter. It also recognizes MS Office documents (those with extensions like .doc, .xls, .ppt, etc.) and opens them, and can also save documents in those formats. For simple documents this shouldn't be a problem but for documents with complex formatting like Tables of Contents, bullets, tables, graphics, etc. there might be some loss of formatting when viewing it in Ooo for MS Office created documents and vice-versa for Ooo created documents.

Additionally, somewhat in the spirit of Firefox extensions,